me a man in haste, but I was in no mood to let some rules stand in the way of speedy incorporation of Vikas into the PSLV. I reiterated that the nozzle was made with the same configuration and materials under the same operating conditions by the same company (Volvo) as that of SEP. In fact, Volvo had supplied three nozzles that could well have been in any Arianne vehicle.

When the others still stuck to the rule book insisting on a test, I played a wild card. 'Why don't you consider the first flight as a high altitude test? Only that you are not doing it in Germany, you are doing it in upper atmosphere, under real conditions.'

There was a momentary silence. It worked.

Now, as I pushed for an early ground test at SEP, I had very little opposition unlike in the previous years. VSSC director Gowarikkar, who was terribly upset with U R Rao's elevation as the ISRO chairman, was now making himself sparse at work as a gesture of protest.

When I returned from Bangalore to my old job at the Liquid Propulsion Systems Centre in Trivandrum with the additional responsibility as the project director of the second and fourth stages of PSLV, Gowarikkar was in a pensive mood. I had little sympathy for him, for I believed U R Rao deserved the post of the chairman much more than anyone else in the organisation, leave alone Gowarikkar. Moreover, I remained sore that Gowarikkar was instrumental in shunting me out of liquid propulsion systems by cooking up the 'furniture scam'. So I was not expecting him to call me and give a sympathetic talk.

'I have caused you much trouble,' he said.

I silently listened, staring at him. He walked towards me and held both my hands in his.

'Nambi, I didn't mean to harm you when I opposed your ideas. Everyone makes mistakes; I, too, have. We all learn from our mistakes. You are a bright promise for ISRO and India.'

I just murmured, 'Okay,' and left the room. I felt happy, not because Gowarikkar, who had created several stumbling blocks to my liquid propulsion plans, apologised to me, but because he told me that I was doing